

MOST MUMBAI POLITICIANS GAVE THE UTTAR PRADESH STHAPNA DIVAS A MISS

RAJ THACKERAY



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MUMBAI | UP and Away

Touted as the Uttar Pradesh Sthapna Divas in Mumbai, January 24 was a day when most politicians decided to stay away from the city while the rest chose to excuse themselves by saying "they weren't invited". The likes of Uddhav Thackeray and Kripashankar Singh travelled out of Mumbai. It is believed that senior politicians avoided the celebrations because they did not want to give Raj Thackeray a reason to question their "loyalty" to Maharashtra. Days before the event, Thackeray's MNS had put up posters to register their protest against the celebration. One poster showed Raj stating that only Maharashtra Divas (May 1) should be celebrated in the state; in another was a picture of an Uttar Pradesh native being kicked by MNS activists.

by Aditi Pai

CHANDIGARH | Graftermath

LALU WANTS TO LAUNCH A HIGH-SPEED TRAIN BETWEEN DELHI AND PATNA WHILE NITISH KUMAR DREAMS OF THE DAY BIHAR WILL BECOME CYBERABAD.

An assertion by newly-anointed Deputy Chief Minister Sukhbir Singh Badal that corruption in Punjab is limited only to the lower rung of the administration has invited a loud laugh and riposte from the Congress. Sukhbir was not so politely reminded of the corruption charges pending against him and his father, Parkash Singh Badal. The Akali scion has asked for at least two years to rid the state's 70-odd civil and police services of corruption and has set up an Administrative Reforms Commission which will submit its report in eight months. "We will implement the recommendations right away but it would take time to feel the difference," he says.

by Ramesh Vinayak



DELHI | Jail Route

At a time when most developers are eyeing greener pastures to beat the slump, Omaxe Ltd has been awarded contracts by the Punjab Infrastructure Development Board and Punjab Public Works Department for the construction of modern jails at Kapurthala and Faridkot. The total estimated cost of making the jails is expected to be Rs 210 crore. With a capacity of more than 2,000 inmates, the jails will be fitted with 50-bed hospitals, training centres and library blocks.

by Nivedita Mukherjee

PATNA | Dream Merchants

Fresh from his visit to Japan and a 300-kmph Bullet Train, Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav has declared he will soon initiate the process of introducing a high-speed train between Delhi and Patna. Not to be left behind, Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar stated that Patna could soon become Cyberabad, if women were made IT-literate and empowered. Both men have clearly overlooked certain home truths. Lalu has forgotten that high-speed trains require special tracks and Kumar that his state's female literacy rate is dismal: 33.57 per cent according to 2001 Census.

by Amitabh Srivastava

MAIL TODAY

LALU PRASAD YADAV

